Proposed Policies to Raise Singapore's Female Labour Force Participation Rate

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Table of Content

Abstract 5
Introduction 6
Methodology 7
Theoretical Frameworks 7
Global Practices 8
Empirical Findings 8
Parental Leave Policies 9
Childcare Policies 9
Equal Pay Policies 10
4-day Work Week 11
Comparative Analysis of Policies 11
Policy Proposal: Rethinking Childcare Through Community 12
Conclusion 13
References 15

Abstract

Singapore's Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) in 2024 stands at 61.25% lagging behind global leaders like Iceland (70.3%). This study proposes policies to enhance FLFPR, addressing barriers rooted in institutional path dependence, such as rigid labour norms and caregiving burdens. Grounded in Human Capital Theory, Feminist Economics, and Institutional Path Dependence, the research employs a multi-stage methodology, analysing demographic and economic data to identify comparable nations (Iceland, New Zealand, Vietnam) and evaluate their policies which aid in increasing their FLFPR.

Comparative analysis reveals Iceland's gender-neutral parental leave and subsidized childcare, New Zealand's flexible leave and free early childhood education, and Vietnam's employer-supported childcare as effective models. These policies reduce the motherhood penalty and enhance maternal workforce attachment. Notably, New Zealand's 2022 Unilever four-day workweek trial and Iceland's 2015–2019 trials demonstrate that flexible work arrangements maintain productivity while improving work-life balance and male caregiving participation.

Drawing on these insights, we propose Community-Supported Workplace Childcare Co-operatives (CWCCs) for Singapore. These employer-supported, government-subsidized childcare hubs, managed cooperatively by parents and community volunteers, integrate AI-driven scheduling and a 32-hour workweek. Inspired by Iceland's flexibility and Vietnam's firm-level innovations, CWCCs mitigate skill depreciation and redistribute caregiving responsibilities, aligning with Singapore's Smart Nation vision and collectivist ethos. Quebec's 7.7% FLFPR increase from universal childcare underscores CWCCs' potential. By challenging outdated norms, CWCCs promise a more equitable, productive labour market, positioning Singapore as a leader in gender-inclusive economic growth.

Introduction

The Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) measures the proportion of working age female adults who participate actively in the workforce (Lim, 2002). While the 20th and early 21st centuries have seen a global rise in FLFPR, progress remains uneven due to persistent structural barriers and socio-cultural norms (Addati et el., 2018).

Many countries have placed growing emphasis on improving women labour market outcomes as part of broader economic and social development agendas (World Bank, 2021). According to the Cobb-Douglas production function, economic growth can be achieved by improving employment population ratio (Weil & Sharma, 2013). Raising FLFPR is a way to achieve that. Thus, enhancing FLFPR is thus not only a gender equity issue but also a pathway to economic growth.

While Singapore's FLFPR has steadily grown to 61.25% in 2023, it still lags the OECD countries in the 15-24 age range (Ministry of Manpower, 2024). This signals untapped economic potential and requires targeted policy response. As Singapore faces demographic pressures such as an ageing population and declining birth rates, fully utilising its human capital becomes increasingly important (Khoo et el., 2021).

The determinants of FLFPR are well-documented in academic literature. Akhtar et el. (2023) reported that bridging the gender wage gap is crucial for economic expansion and workplace diversification. Meanwhile, Sulalman et el. (2023) highlighted that affordable and high-quality childcare supports maternal employment and reshapes the organisational stigma around working mothers. This reduces the opportunity cost borne by mothers for caregiving.

However, translating these insights into actionable policy remains a challenge. There is a lack of systematic policy design frameworks that adapt academic findings into country-specific contexts. The purpose of this study is therefore to examine and evaluate international policy models designed to increase FLFPR and construct evidence-based, contextually relevant public policy proposals for Singapore to raise its FLFPR.

Methodology

This study adopts a multi-stage approach to proposing policy interventions aimed at increasing Singapore's FLFPR. The methodology integrates empirical analysis together with theoretical evaluation to ensure policy recommendations and robust and relevant.

We begin by studying the demographic and economic factors that distinguish Singapore from other economies. We recognize that policy effectiveness is highly dependent on local context. We aim to identify countries that are demographically and economically similar to Singapore. This is achieved by consolidating country-level economic and demographic data and calculating a similarity score based on weighted economic and FLFPR metrics. By focusing on countries similar to Singapore, we ensure that the policies we study are relevant and transferable to Singapore.

We will then use the Human Capital Theory, Feminist Economic and Institutional Path Dependence frameworks to understand the effect and influence that these policies have on the FLFPR. This allows us to select aspects that we believe will be useful in Singapore's situation. Finally, we will use the same theoretical frameworks to design a policy that we believe will support an increase in Singapore's FLFPR.

Theoretical Frameworks

Theoretical frameworks provide a structured lens in which the effects of public policy can be rigorously evaluated. (Nilson, 2015). In this segment, we will briefly elaborate on the conceptualisation of the three theoretical frameworks utilised in evaluating international policy and structuring our own policy designs.

Human Capital Theory (Becker, 1993)

Becker conceptualised Human Capital Theory to illustrate that societies and individuals derive economic returns from investments in education, training and health. These investments increase an individual's productivity and thus contributes to economic growth. The theory emphasizes that skills and knowledge are assets that yield long-term returns when maintained properly. As women often temporarily leave the workforce due to caregiving responsibilities, they risk skill depreciation, hence reducing their employability (Lee & Tang, 2013).

Feminist Economics (Folbre, 1994)

Folbre's feminist economics highlights how traditional models overlook and undervalue unpaid care work, disproportionately performed by women. This neglect contributes to the gender wage gap, occupational segregation, and women's under-representation in the workforce. Her framework argues that public policy must recognize and redistribute caregiving responsibilities. Without systemic support, women will continue to face structural barriers to full labour force participation and economic equality.

Institutional Path Dependence (Badulescu, 2016)

Institutional path dependence the phenomenon where policies, norms and institutional arrangements tend to persist over time due to self-reinforcing mechanisms like vested interest, sunk costs and culture. Outdated and suboptimal institutional structures persist despite the presence of efficient and equitable alternatives. They continue to define the labour market, welfare systems and gender roles despite changing economic conditions. Policies designed to raise FLFPR need to overcome these longstanding institutional structures that serves as the barriers to entry for females.

Global Practices

Empirical Findings

This section conducts a comparative analysis of FLFPR policies in Iceland, New Zealand and Vietnam. By evaluating policy mechanisms and causal impacts, the study offers insights for Singapore in 2024, where FLFPR is 62.25% for ages 15+ (World Bank, n.d.), to design a novel policy incorporating distinct from existing measures.

Iceland, New Zealand, and Vietnam were selected for their high FLFPR and diverse economic and demographic contexts, offering valuable policy insights for Singapore. Iceland's FLFPR is 70.3% for women aged 15+ driven by robust gender equality policies, a small population of 398,300, and a high GDP per capita of $90,111, enabling welfare-driven approaches in a developed economy (World Bank, n.d.; World Population Review, n.d.). New Zealand's FLFPR is 66.9% for ages 15+, supported by a population of 5.3 million and a GDP per capita of $48,234, aligning closely with Singapore's economic profile and offering lessons from a comparable developed nation (World Bank, n.d.; World Population Review, n.d.). Vietnam's FLFPR is 69.1% for ages 15+, driven by economic necessity and a large informal sector (40%

of female employment), with a population of 101.6 million and a lower GDP per capita of $4,986, highlighting scalable policies despite limited fiscal resources (World Bank, n.d.; IFC, 2019, p. 29; World Population Review, n.d.). Their high Comprehensive Similarity Indices and low New Similarity Scores (Iceland: 0.286, New Zealand: 0.341, Vietnam: 0.593) underscore their relevance for designing policies to enhance Singapore's FLFPR of 62.25%.

Parental Leave Policies

Parental leave policies are instrumental in promoting gender equity in caregiving and minimizing the long-term career impacts often faced by mothers.

Iceland's gender-neutral parental leave policy, introduced in 2000 and expanded in 2021, provides 12 months of paid leave—six months per parent, non-transferable. This encourages shared caregiving and has led to a 90% paternal uptake, making Iceland a global leader in equitable leave. The policy has helped reduce maternal career interruptions and lowered the motherhood penalty to between 3–5% (Guðný Björk Eydal & Ásdís A. Arnalds, 2024).

New Zealand's paid parental leave, introduced in 2002 and updated in 2022, offers 26 weeks of leave at a maximum of NZ$788.66 per week (Inland Revenue, n.d.; Tan, J., 2025). It is fully transferable between parents, allowing caregiving flexibility. However, survey data shows mothers prefer 69 weeks of leave, suggesting a mismatch between policy and parental needs (Noy & Sin, 2021).

Vietnam's maternity leave policy, revised in 2020, provides six months of paid leave, plus extra days for multiple births or health issues. While it supports income continuity and job protection for mothers in the formal sector, the absence of paternal leave reinforces traditional gender roles (Dezan Shira et al., 2019).

Childcare Policies

Accessible and affordable childcare plays a critical role in supporting maternal employment and enabling gender-equitable workforce participation.

Iceland provides heavily subsidized childcare, with monthly fees ranging from $200 to $280, scaled according to household income and number of children. This ensures affordability across income levels and enables mothers to remain in the workforce without being overburdened by childcare costs (Yvette Lind, 2024).

New Zealand offers 20 hours of free Early Childhood Education (ECE) per week for children aged 3 to 5, along with additional subsidies for low-income families (Ministry of Education NZ, n.d.). Despite these provisions, 7.7% of mothers, particularly Māori and Pacific women continue to face barriers to accessing childcare, limiting their ability to participate fully in paid work (Chappell, Harris, & Sin, 2021).

Vietnam supports childcare primarily through employer-provided subsidies, ranging from VND 10,000 to 150,000 monthly. Some firms, such as Feng Tay, also offer onsite childcare facilities to close the 15% gap in public childcare coverage. These measures are particularly beneficial for female migrant workers, improving their ability to maintain stable employment while managing care responsibilities (IFC, 2019, pp. 33–35).

Equal Pay Policies

Equal pay legislation plays a vital role in addressing gender wage disparities, reducing occupational segregation, and promoting transparency in compensation structures.

Iceland implemented the Equal Pay Certification in 2018, requiring companies with 25 or more employees to verify that they offer equal pay for equal work. This mandatory certification has helped reduce wage disparities by addressing structural inequalities and fostering greater wage transparency (Government of Iceland, n.d.).

New Zealand enforces equal pay through the Equal Pay Act 1972, which was significantly amended in 2020. These reforms contributed to narrowing the national gender pay gap to 8.2% in 2024. Women now represent 56.7% of senior leadership roles, and the gender pay gap in the public service has fallen to 6.1%. However, persistent challenges remain, especially in terms of occupational segregation and higher pay gaps for ethnic minorities and persons with disabilities (Public Service Commission, n.d.).

Vietnam established the Gender Equality Law in 2006 (Law No. 73/2006/QH11), mandating equal pay, equal access to employment and training, and leadership opportunities for women. While this law promotes formal-sector protections, implementation remains uneven—particularly in the informal sector, which accounts for around 40% of female employment—limiting its overall effectiveness (IFC, 2019).

4-day Work Week

Many countries have trialled 4-day workweeks to test research suggesting such models maintain productivity while improving well-being and work-life balance. (Hamermesh & Biddle, 2025)

New Zealand trialled its 4-day workweek with Unilever in 2022 (Unilever, 2022) and the results showed that work-life conflicts fell by 67% while maintaining productivity levels as absenteeism levels fell and employee's engagement rose (4 day week, 2025). Importantly, male employees spent more time on caregiving, creating a more balanced division of responsibilities and enabling women to pursue other interests.

The United Kingdom similarly also trialled its 4-day workweek across various sectors in 2022. Lewis et el. (2023) that employees were less stressed, and levels of anxiety, fatigue and sleep issues decreased. Employees reported improved work-life balance, and 60% said they were better able to manage paid work and caregiving. Notably, 92% of participating organisations chose to continue with the 4-day workweek after the trial.

Iceland held its 4-day workweek trial between 2015 and 2019, and results in many workers moving to shorter working hours (BBC, 2021). These trials led unions to renegotiate working patterns, and Iceland now records one of the shortest average weekly working hours globally (World Population Review, 2025). The reduced working hours led to workers feeling less pressured and improving their work-life balance.

Comparative Analysis of Policies

Parental leave design plays a key role in shaping gender-equitable caregiving. Iceland's non-transferable, gender-neutral policy achieved 90% paternal uptake and reduced the motherhood penalty to 3–5%. In contrast, New Zealand's fully transferable scheme results in low paternal uptake (5–10%), sustaining a higher motherhood penalty (5–10%). Vietnam's maternity-only leave, though supportive of formal-sector mothers, excludes fathers, reinforcing traditional roles.

Childcare accessibility influences maternal employment elasticity. Iceland offers income-scaled, heavily subsidized childcare, facilitating continuous workforce attachment. New Zealand provides 20 hours of free Early Childhood Education (ECE) weekly, but 7.7% of mothers, especially Māori and Pacific women—face access barriers. Vietnam addresses a 15%

public childcare gap through employer subsidies and onsite childcare, especially in manufacturing sectors.

Equal pay legislation affects wage equity and occupational segregation. Iceland mandates Equal Pay Certification for firms with 25+ employees, fostering transparency. New Zealand's amended Equal Pay Act narrowed the gender pay gap to 8.2% and increased female senior leadership to 56.7%. Vietnam's Gender Equality Law provides a legal framework but has limited reach in the informal sector, which employs 40% of women.

Lastly, 4-day workweek trials in Iceland and New Zealand showed enhanced well-being, greater male caregiving, and stable productivity. Vietnam has not implemented similar reforms.

Given Singapore's economic profile, fiscal capacity, and caregiving challenges, hybrid approaches, policies such as non-transferable parental leave for fathers, income-scaled childcare subsidies, and pay transparency mandates may offer the most effective and context-sensitive strategies for raising female labour force participation.

Policy Proposal: Rethinking Childcare Through Community

The nature of work will undergo radical changes in the wake of developments in AI and hybrid models. Kahn (2024) describes how these changes will enable a productivity boom that will propel economies. As Singapore stride towards taking advantage of this technological advancement and becoming a smart nation, it must also rethink how caregiving is supported. In a post-industrial knowledge economy, flexible caregiving is no longer a welfare issue but a productivity imperative (Eisler, R., 2013). Claudia Goldin's (2023) Nobel Prize-winning research highlights that persistent gender gaps in labour force participation are due to structural incompatibilities between work and care responsibilities. Thus, labour reforms to enable better work-life management must accompany Singapore's technological progress.

The case of mothers aged 15-24 in Singapore facing the sharpest drop in participation is consistently attributed to inadequate childcare infrastructure and the "motherhood penalty" (Blau & Kahn, 2017). To address this, we propose a hybrid policy model: Community-Supported Workplace Childcare Co-operatives (CWCCs), an initiative that integrates flexible care, cooperative management, and AI-driven scheduling.

Inspired by Iceland's childcare flexibility and Vietnam's inclusion of informal workers, CWCCs are employer-supported, government-subsidized childcare hubs located within or near

workplaces. Guided by feminist economic principles, these centres are co-operatively managed by parents, employers, and community volunteers to redistribute caregiving responsibility across society.

Steve Glaveski (2018) critiques the 40-hour workweek as an outdated model that dates to 19th century socialism. Despite changes in technology and shifting job demands, employers display status quo bias in retaining the 40-hour workweek, making it a case of institutional path dependence. CWCCs aims to move beyond this outdated model by allowing flexible working hours (7 AM–9 PM) and reducing the workweek to 32-hours without career penalties. We aim to leverage on AI-powered scheduling systems to dynamically match parents' work hours to childcare availability, ensuring efficiency and personalisation.

From a Human Capital Theory perspective, CWCCs mitigate the productivity loss associated with maternal career breaks by reducing the caretaking burdens on women, allowing them to preserve their skills and reduce re-entry friction. Simultaneously, this model aligns with Singapore's collectivist institutional path, building on established structures like Residents' Committees and the PA network (Badulescu, 2016), enabling scalable community mobilisation.

Moreover, co-operative childcare builds intergenerational reciprocity, addressing Singapore's ageing population while closing the care gap — a form of social innovation uniquely suited to high-density urban environments.

Studies in Sweden, Canada, and Quebec show that publicly supported, high-quality childcare systems can significantly increase female employment. Quebec's universal childcare program, for instance, led to an increase of 7.7% in FLFPR (Baker, Gruber, & Milligan, 2008). Additionally, when Iceland introduced flexible paternity leave and on-site care, maternal workforce attachment remained stable post-birth.

Conclusion

Singapore's Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) in 2024 stands 35.5% for ages 15–24, lagging global leaders like Iceland (70.3%). This study, grounded in Human Capital Theory, Feminist Economics, and Institutional Path Dependence, proposes CWCC to address barriers to female workforce participation, particularly for mothers.

The CWCC model introduces employer-supported, government-subsidized childcare hubs managed cooperatively by parents and community volunteers. Integrated with AI-driven

scheduling and flexible hours, CWCCs align with Singapore's Smart Nation vision and collectivist ethos. Drawing from Iceland's childcare flexibility and Vietnam's firm-level innovations, this policy mitigates the motherhood penalty and skill depreciation, preserving women's human capital. Quebec's universal childcare, which boosted FLFPR by 7.7%, underscores its potential.

By challenging outdated labour and caregiving norms, these policies address institutional path dependence, offering scalable solutions tailored to Singapore's urban context. Implementing them will require coordination but promises a more equitable, productive labour market, positioning Singapore as a leader in gender-inclusive economic growth.

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